EU staffing crunch hinders response to Chinese trade pressure

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EU staffing crunch hinders response to Chinese trade pressure
By Koen Verhelst · Nov 6, 2026, 6:00 AM · View in your browser

BRUSSELS — Brussels has ambitious plans to bolster Europe’s trade defenses. But the officials responsible for enforcing them face a more mundane problem: a severe staff shortage.

With European manufacturers struggling to compete against cheaper imports, particularly from China, the Commission is finding it hard to keep up with demands to investigate unfair trade practices. Industry representatives warn that delays stretching beyond a year can make the difference between survival and closure for companies already under severe financial pressure.

“The Commission is informing industries that there is a queue of at least one to one-and-a-half years,” said Ruud Wassen, EU managing director at Consello, a U.S. consulting firm.

A trade lawyer said such holdups can prove fatal.

“EU companies are going under while waiting for a reaction. They have to beg for a year before they’re heard,” said the lawyer, who was granted anonymity to speak about sensitive cases.

The lawyer usually represents exporters to Europe — many of them Chinese — on the opposite side of trade investigations launched at the request of European industry. “Even if I’m more on the free-trade side of things,” the lawyer said, “this problem is obvious.”

Four other trade lawyers representing European businesses told POLITICO that long wait times have resulted in their clients having to close production before Brussels imposes protective duties — and in some cases before an investigation even gets off the ground.

The companies themselves are reluctant to speak publicly for fear of jeopardizing their relations with the officials handling their complaints.

French President Emmanuel Macron has warned that Europe’s trade defenses can work too slowly to save companies undercut by subsidized Chinese competitors.

“When you have a Chinese challenger based on all those subsidies, marking a price at 20% to 30% under yours, if two years later the Commission says: ‘You were right.’ But you are dead — I mean, thank you, happy I was right, [but] it’s over,” Macron said in a speech to business leaders in Antwerp earlier this year.

The European Commission’s deputy chief spokesperson, Olof Gill, told POLITICO that “Directorate G [for trade defense] is the largest directorate in DG Trade and has recently been reinforced. In the context of the directorate’s workload continuing to increase, the Commission is currently exploring options to

strengthen it further."

Get in line

If an EU company believes it is being unfairly undercut by foreign competitors, it can ask Directorate G to investigate suspected dumping or unfair subsidies. Under EU rules, Brussels has 45 days to decide whether to open an investigation once a complaint has been formally lodged.

But there's a catch. According to lawyers, the Commission asks companies to hold off on filing complaints while officials carry out time-consuming preparatory work.

That allows Brussels to meet its statutory deadlines on paper, even as companies and industry groups wait for investigators to take up their cases.

Once launched, an investigation becomes public and typically takes about a year, with officials visiting factories abroad and assessing the impact of imports on European industry. This can result in protective duties, as in the recent case of PET spunbond, a material used in construction, on which the EU executive imposed anti-dumping duties of up to 48.1 percent .

The Commission opened 32 new trade-defense investigations in 2025, acknowledging in an annual report that "this persistent high level of activity continues to exert pressure on the trade defense services." Another 21 reviews of existing measures were launched.

The products affected range widely — from robot lawn mowers to paint pigments. Around a third of the new cases concern chemicals, a sector under particular pressure from Chinese competitors.

Individual companies are getting in line. Chemicals giant INEOS has 20 complaints pending, according to Steve Dossett, CEO of the group's PVC subsidiary.

"We do scratch our heads wondering whether DG Trade is adequately resourced to address these complaints in a meaningful time [frame], because of some of the pressures that the European chemical industry in general is under," Dossett told POLITICO in a recent interview.

AEGIS Europe, an umbrella group representing more than two dozen manufacturing associations with combined annual sales of €500 billion, argued in a recent report that the Commission was failing to devote sufficient staff and funding to enforcing existing trade-defense rules.

Some 140 people work in the DG Trade department that deals with unfair imports, according to the AEGIS report, around 100 of whom are trained in trade defense instruments.

By comparison, the U.S. Department of Commerce's enforcement and compliance division has a staff of 440, according to AEGIS, which estimates that Directorate G needs at least 50 extra employees. Chemical industry association Cefic called for at least 20 more staff in 2025.

Hiring isn't the only solution: Outsourcing some technical work is common elsewhere in the Commission, but Wassen said DG Trade has been reluctant to take that approach.

"They really should be more creative. Outside firms could certainly do calculations, for instance," he told POLITICO. "But they are very careful."

New weapons, same problem

Despite the staffing crunch, Brussels is pressing ahead with plans to strengthen its trade defense arsenal , with Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič expected to announce a package of new measures in early December.

One idea under consideration is a new “kill switch,” proposed by Macron and German Chancellor Friedrich Merz, that would allow the Commission to restrict access to the single market when a country is found to be destabilizing it.

Unlike the EU’s existing trade “bazooka,” the Anti-Coercion Instrument, the proposed mechanism would give the Commission greater freedom to act without extensive prior consultation with EU governments.

But developing such instruments requires time and capacity — precisely what DG Trade already lacks.

There’s little prospect of immediate relief. Directorate G has been unable to hire any new staff in 2026, according to an EU official who was also granted anonymity because they weren’t authorized to speak to the press.

The official questioned whether developing new instruments was the best use of scarce resources given that investigators are already struggling to keep up with existing cases, including factory inspections in China and India.

And even if Brussels did find the money to expand its enforcement teams, relief wouldn’t come overnight.

“Let’s say you double the staff today, it doesn’t mean the capacity doubles,” the trade lawyer said. “The onboarding is going to take a lot of time.”

Carlo Martuscelli contributed reporting.

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